

The Ratified Minutes of the Policy and General Meeting

OXFORD STUDENTS LIBERAL ASSOCIATION

16.00 on the 16th May 2026, Trinity Term, the Swan & Castle

Present: the **Senior President & Ex-President** (Harry Morgan, *Pembroke*), the **Junior President** (Thomas Dorey, *Oxford Brookes*), the **Junior President-Elect** (Oliver Davis, *Pembroke*), the **Junior Treasurer** (Antonio Reis, *St Hugh's*), the **Junior Secretary** (Henry Nicholls, *Lady Margaret Hall*), the **Senior Treasurer** (Issy Rothwell, *Somerville*), the **Senior Secretary & Ex-President** (Zagham Farhan, *University*), the **Social Secretary** (Poppy Watts, *Oxford Brookes*), the **Director of Communications** (Natasha Clyne, *Corpus Christi*), the **Publications Editor** (Oskar Doepke, *Pembroke*), the **Webmaster** (Kshitij Wadkar, *Christ Church*), the **Membership Officer & Vice Returning Officer** (Joseph Laurencin, *Lincoln*), the **Returning Officer** (Aaron Zeleke, *University*).

Absent:

Alyna Shahzad (Communications Officer, *Oxford Brookes*), Hannah Stewart (Women's Officer, *Keble*).

The Senior President opens the meeting at 16:10

Policy Motions

1. This house would rejoin the single market

The Junior President proposes the policy motion 'this house would re-join the single market'; his arguments, inspired by Max Wilkinson, revolve around this being a more concrete way in which we can align ourselves with Europe more closely for the sake of economic gain.

The Senior Secretary argues strongly against the idea of rejoining the customs union, the single market, and the EEA, largely because he views this as the worst of both worlds: we neither get a say in what's going on, and we lose out on some of the economic benefits, whilst also being bound by freedom of movement and regulations set in Brussels.

The Junior Treasurer argues that European collaboration has helped Britain to a greater extent than any other form of foreign policy, and thus rejoining the European single market is a step in the right direction.

The Senior Secretary then reminds us that it would be extremely difficult to rejoin the EU on the same terms that we used to have; concessions made by us could include adoption of the Euro and complete freedom of movement, both of which would be extremely unpopular in this country today.

The Junior Treasurer proposes an amendment to the motion, suggesting that it should instead be 'this house supports re-entry into the European Union under the our previous terms'; the amended motion passes¹.

2. This house would stick to the original plans for HS2

The President-Elect proposes the policy motion 'this house would stick to the original plans for HS2'; his main arguments in favour are that such a choice would certainly increase social and economic mobility across the country, and, given that so many other nations have successfully implemented similar projects, surely we should be able to financially justify such a project.

The motion is then amended by the Senior Secretary to 'this house would stick to the original plans for HS2 and supports widespread expansion of high-speed rail across the country'. The motion passes.²

3. This house supports the abolition of the hereditary Head of State

The Senior Secretary proposes the motion 'this house supports the abolition of the hereditary head of state'; he argues primarily that the monarchy, as a constitutional head of state, is undemocratic, and asks why we would want to live in a country where we are subjects of someone who is the head of state as a result of the nature of their birth. He also disagrees with the idea that MPs, MSPs, and other government officials all have to swear allegiance to the monarch, not to the people or to specific principles.

The Senior President raises the question over who would actually end up being President if we became a Presidential Republic; The Senior Secretary's response revolves around the fact that many nations have Presidents who are uncontroversial and not a 'Trump-like' figure.

The President-Elect argues that the royal family are effectively trained to be neutral, and thus we are very unlikely to end up having a President who is as politically neutral as the royal family are currently.

The Junior Secretary points out that we could still elect King Charles to be the President, and that we would not have to remove any of the grandeur by removing a hereditary monarch.

¹ Only the Senior Secretary and Returning Officer voting against.

² Only the Senior President and Director of Communications voting against.

The Senior Secretary then says that, as a Liberal or as a Democrat, living in a state whose highest authority is there by the nature of their birth doesn't make sense.

The President-Elect suggests an amendment, that 'this house supports a reduction of the entitlements and privileges of the royal family'; the Senior President suggests another amendment, that 'this house would change the allegiance to the crown to allegiance to the people; neither pass.

The original motion fails.

Financial Report

The Junior Treasurer declares that OSLA is in a stable financial position, despite making a very narrow loss so far this term. The bank balance currently is in a healthy position, at around £2,000, but OSLA is currently operating at a slight loss, and so he says that we need to push for either greater attendance or altering the pricing structure slightly, so as to break even.

We are still waiting for one member to pay his existing debts resulting from attending last year's party conference, which, once repaid, would put us in a stronger position.

Projections are that we will make a loss of £200, at the current rate; however, this number was produced before the most recent L&L held at the Old Fire Station, which turned a profit.

The Senior President moves to pass the Junior Treasurer's Financial Report; it is seconded by the Senior Treasurer and passes without objection.

Motion to amend the Rules and Standing Orders

The Senior Secretary proposes his rules change, which makes it easier for the constitution to be changed, by way of many matters now being classified as standing orders instead of rules. In terms of constitutional changes, the Senior Secretary proposes several alterations to the way in which elections are run, primarily hosting a full Poll for contested elections.

The Junior Treasurer raises an objection to the point about prohibited societies and their involvement with OSLA committee. The Senior Secretary explains that the long standing prohibition on people involved in other political societies standing for election is to 'prevent the generic student hack' from being able to move between political societies with the sole purpose of winning some form of election.

There is then a discussion about members of the committee being involved with student press, arising from several issues that arose last term. It is suggested that if you are simultaneously on the committees of OSLA and a student newspaper, it is impossible to prevent a conflict of interest, and so this becomes a very difficult issue to resolve. A point is then discussed about what should constitute involvement with the student press, given that the Cherwell, for example, has over 200 people involved.

An alteration is proposed by the Junior Secretary, to make it so that any communication between student media and anyone on OSLA committee needs to be explicitly declared to all relevant parties.

A discussion then arises in relation to the rules change concerning who should be able to run in OSLA elections if they are also involved with other political societies, concerning which political issues should count as being against the values of the Liberal Democrats and OSLA. The Green Party, in particular, is thoroughly discussed, and will be reconsidered at a later date.

It is agreed to revisit the issue of conflicts of interest.

Further issues that are discussed are the way in which people can re-join OSLA if they have resigned their membership. It is worth noting that the majority of these changes have been made to standing orders, and thus can be changed by Council at any time.

The Motion is passed without objection.

The President closes the meeting at 17:35

Minuted by **Henry Nicholls** (Junior Secretary, *Lady Margaret Hall*),

Edited by **Zagham Farhan** (Senior Secretary, *University*),

Minutes ratified by Council at a meeting on 19th July 2026.